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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1963-1973

Coverage Date: 1963-1973

Place Coverage: Dobe Area, Botswana And Namibia

Section Title(S)

Case 2. Kxau whips his wife //Kushe in dispute over blanket • Case 3. Two young men play fight and it turns serious

Commentary. The wife was unable to stop her husband from leaving, but she did get the blanket and she won the moral victory by provoking him to lose his temper and beat her in public, thereby invoking strong public criticism of his behavior. It was interesting that she chose to fight him while “wearing” both the bucket of water and the child, making her morally a doubly redoubtable target; to spill water and strike a child in anger are both strongly frowned upon by the !Kung. The husband had to set both bucket and child on the ground before taking a swing at his wife. The couple had a long history of strife. This same husband had provoked two other fights involving adultery during my 3 years of fieldwork. One was a battle royal at /Xai/xai in 1964 in which four people were injured, including Kxau's wife *and* his lover, while Kxau himself was untouched.

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Case 3. Two young men play fight and it turns serious

I witnessed this fight at Dobe in December 1964. Kashe and Bo were unmarried young men in their late twenties who had just returned from a period of working on the Tswana cattle posts in the East. Both men had a reputation for fighting. Kashe had been involved in at least three other scraps and Bo in two others in recent years. The causes of the fight are obscure. Kashe accused Bo of *za-ing* his brother-in-law and he wanted to kill him because of the insult. Others of their agemates thought he was joking until he attacked one of them, a man named /Tishe, and landed several blows.

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Kashe called out a challenge to Bo: "You and /Tishe together can't lay a hand on me."

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"You shouldn't talk like that," Bo replied, "we are all men here and we are all strong."

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Kashe said, "If you don't like my words then let's get into it."

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The two men started grappling and fought their way out of the camp to a clearing 100 meters to the east. (I was told later that they moved out of the camp to fight because they didn't want the women to see their genitals exposed through their ragged shorts.) At first there was a playful element to the fighting, but it soon became serious. They punched and grappled and each got a hammerlock on the other. Kashe got Bo down on the ground and gouged his eyes with his nails so that Bo's face was covered with blood. Many people gathered round the fighters, and the tension became very high. Some tried to break it up, but others started side fights. Bo's mother, aged 60, attacked Kashe's mother's sister, aged 55. An aunt of Bo's wanted to pile in, but her husband prevented her and *they* started fighting. One man exploded with irritation at the fighting women: "Why should you fight? The boys are not using arrows or spears. Why should you start a big one?" Kashe's father yelled back, "If this is a big fight, let's get started. We are all men here. Get me my arrows!"

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